

1989

Chit-Chat

August: IRC

Jarkko Oikarinen, the founder of Internet Relay Chat (IRC), wrote the first IRC client and server at the University of Oulu, Finland, in August of 1988.

Jarkko wanted a system that would hold conversations in real-time and have features of a Bulletin Board System that could dial into computers via the phone line to upload and download data, read news, and send messages. The first IRC server was addressed at tolsun.oulu.fi.

In the meantime, the University of Denver and Oregon State University in the US had begun to run their own IRC servers after getting a copy of the IRC program from one of Jarkko's friends. The three universities combined to form one IRC network. Later on, this network grew even larger to encompass many US universities, the Finnish National Network Funet, and the Scandinavian branch of the network called Nordunet. In a year's time, there were 40 servers worldwide.

Over the years, quite a few IRC networks branched from the main IRC servers. Some of them were EFnet, Undernet, RFC, Dalnet, oz.org, IRCnet and Freenode. The first non-Finnish person to use IRC was Vijay Subramaniam, a student of the University of Denver.

Cyber-crime

In the first cyber espionage case to make international headlines, hackers in West Germany were arrested in 1989 for breaking into US government and corporate computers and selling the data to the Soviet KGB. Three of them were arrested and a fourth suspected hacker committed suicide. Since the information stolen was not classified, the hackers were only fined and sentenced to probation.